PREREQUISITE TO DIGNITY OF LABOUR



This essay was written in Marseille in 1941. Part of it appeared in Cheval de Troie *in 1947 and it is now included in the collection made by Albertine Thévenon of Simone Weil's writings about her factory experience. The same collection,* La Condition Ouvrière *contains Simone Weil's journal and the notes she made after her day's work in the Renault, Alsthom and Basse-Indres Forges factories in Paris. In it she argues against the so-called 'rationalization' or 'taylorization' of labour, which reduces the worker to a series of gestures unconnected with reality. It dates from the period during which Simone Weil had become increasingly engaged in her struggle with the Christian church and contrasts vividly with articles written closer to the time of her employment in the factories, for example* 'La vie et la grève des ouvrières metallos'.

There is in all manual work and all work performed to order, that's to say in all real labour, an ineradicable element of constraint which would exist in even the most equitable of societies. The reason is that such work is governed by necessity and not by purpose. It is performed not for a result but because of a need, 'since you've got to

make a living' as people say whose existence is spent doing just that. It means exerting effort whose sole end is to secure no more than what one already has, while failure to exert such effort results in losing it. But in human effort, the only source of energy is desire. It is not in a person's nature to desire what he already has. Desire is a tendency, the start of a movement towards something, towards a point from which one is absent. If, at the very outset, this movement doubles back on itself towards its point of departure, a person turns round and round like a squirrel in a cage or a prisoner in a condemned cell. Constant turning soon produces revulsion. All workers, especially though not exclusively those who work under inhumane conditions, are easily the victims of revulsion, exhaustion and disgust and the strongest are often the worst affected.

Existence is not an end in itself but merely the framework upon which all good, both real and imagined, may be built. When all objectives vanish and existence appears starkly stripped of everything, it no longer bears any relation to what is good. Indeed it becomes evil. And it is precisely then, when existence is substituted for all absent ends, that it becomes an end in itself, the only object of desire. When desire is directed like that towards sheer naked evil, the soul lives in the same horror as when violent death is imminent. In the past, that state could last an entire lifetime, as for example when a man disarmed by his enemy's sword found his life spared. In exchange for his life he would exhaust all his energies all day, every day, as a slave, with nothing on which to pin his hopes except the possibility of not being whipped or not being killed. The only good objective for him was existence itself. The ancients used to say that the day a man became a slave half his soul was taken from him.

A similar kind of slavery persists whenever people find themselves in the same position on the first and the last day of a month, of a year, or of twenty years' effort. The similarity lies in its being equally impossible for them to desire more than they already possess or to direct effort towards the acquisition of what is good. Effort is for survival.

The unit of time is a day and they oscillate like a ball bouncing off two walls, from work to sleep, working so as to eat, eating so as to continue to work and so on *ad nauseam*. In this sort of existence, everything is an intermediary, a means from which all finality is excluded. The manufactured object is a means. It will be sold. Who could invest in it his or her idea of the good? Material objects, tools, the worker's body and even his soul are a means of manufacturing. Necessity is omnipresent, good nowhere. This is the sole reason for people's present loss of morale. It is the unchanging, essential working condition. We must look for the reasons why in the past there has been no similar demoralization.

The emptiness of such a life is only bearable either through enormous physical strength, in which effort is scarcely perceived, or through total moral paralysis. In the absence of these, compensations are necessary. One is the hope, either for oneself or for one's children, of occupying a different position in society. Another, of the same sort, is mindless pleasure or violence. In both, illusion is substituted for objective. On Sunday, for example, people want to forget that they have to work, so they dress and spend as though they did not. Vanity has to be satisfied and illusions of power easily procured by abandon. Enjoyments of this sort act like a drug and drugs are always a temptation to those who are suffering. Revolution itself is a similar sort of compensation. It is ambition transposed to the collective level, the wild ambition that all workers shall soar above the working condition itself.

Most revolutionary feeling, though initially a revolt against injustice, often becomes very rapidly as it has done in the past, a workers' imperialism exactly analogous to national imperialism. Its aim is the total and unlimited domination of one collectivity over all humanity and all aspects of human life. The absurdity of it lies in the fact that under such a regime, the dominators, being themselves workers, would be unable to dominate. As a revolt against the injustices of society, the idea of revolution is right and

proper. But as a revolt against the essential misery of the working condition it is misleading, for no revolution will get rid of the latter.

Belief in revolution holds the greater sway, however, since the misery of the working condition is more keenly felt than injustice itself. In people's minds the one is rarely distinguished from the other. The phrase 'opium of the people' which Marx used appropriately enough to describe religion when it had failed itself, applies essentially to revolution. The hope of a revolution to come satisfies a craving for adventure, of escaping from necessity, which again is a reaction against misery. In adolescence this same craving is shown in a taste for crime fiction and a tendency towards delinquency. It was naive of the bourgeoisie to believe that all would be well if they transferred to the people the principle that governs the middle classes, namely the acquisition of wealth. They did as much as they could in this direction by introducing piece-work and extending exchange between urban and rural areas. But all that did was increase dissatisfaction to the level of dangerous frustration, and the reason was simple. The acquisition of money as the object of desire and effort cannot take place under conditions within which it is impossible to become enriched. A small industrialist or businessman may enrich himself and become a big industrialist or a big businessman; a teacher, a writer or a minister is rich or poor according to circumstance but a worker who becomes rich ceases to be a worker and the same is nearly always true of a peasant. A worker cannot be smitten by the desire for money without wishing to escape, either with or without his companions, from the working condition.

The workers' universe excludes purpose. Purpose does not penetrate it except for very short periods always regarded as exceptional. The rapid development of new countries such as the US and the USSR produces change at such a rate that from one day to the next it seems there are fresh expectations, more and more things to desire and to covet. This frenzied social reconstruction was the great

attraction of Russian communism, by coincidence as it happened, since it had to do with the economic state of the country and not with revolution or Marxist doctrine. When a system of metaphysics is based on brief, temporary and exceptional circumstances, as in the case of the American and the Russian, it is ill-founded. The family acquires purpose in the form of children to be brought up. But unless one aspires on their behalf to a different social position – rare as these social advances are – the prospect of children condemned to the same existence provides no relief from its painful emptiness. This emptiness weighs heavily and it is felt and suffered by many of low intelligence and little culture. Those whose position in society protects them from it cannot judge fairly the actions of those who bear it all their lives. It does not kill but is perhaps as painful as hunger, possibly more painful. It might be literally true that bread is less necessary than the relief of such pain.

There is one form of relief and one only. Only one thing makes monotony bearable and that is beauty, the light of the eternal. It is in respect of one thing only that human nature can bear for the soul's desire to be directed towards not what could be or will be, but towards what exists, and that is in respect of beauty. Everything beautiful is the object of desire but one desires that it be not otherwise, that it be unchanged, that it be exactly what it is. One looks with desire at a clear starry night and one desires exactly the sight before one's eyes. Since the people are forced to direct all their desires towards what they already possess, beauty is made for them and they for it. For other social classes, poetry is a luxury but the people need poetry as they need bread. Not the poetry closed inside words: by itself that is no use to them. They need poetry to be the very substance of daily life. Such poetry can come from one source only and that is God. The poetry can only be religion. There is no stratagem, no procedure, no reform or reversal whereby purpose can enter the world in which workers are placed by the working condition itself. But this entire world may be

connected to the one true purpose. It may be linked to God. The condition of the workers is one in which the hunger for purpose that is the very being of all people cannot be satisfied except by God. And it is their exclusive privilege. They alone possess it. In all other conditions of life, without exception, specific aims govern activity. And there is not a single aim, including the salvation of one or many souls, which may not act as a screen and hide God. The screen must be pierced through detachment. For workers there is no screen. Nothing separates them from God. They have only to lift their heads. Therein lies the greatest difficulty for them. Unlike other people they do not have too much of something which must be shed with effort. They have too little of something. They have too few intermediaries. Asking people to think of God and to offer him their pain and suffering is no help at all.

People go to church specifically to pray, yet we know they could not do so unless their attention were drawn through intermediaries towards God. The architecture of the church itself, the images which fill it, the words of the liturgy and prayer, the ritual gestures of the priest are all intermediaries. By fixing attention on them it is guided towards God. How much more necessary then is the provision of such intermediaries in a place where someone goes merely to make a living! In the workplace all thought is dragged down to earth. It is clearly not possible to put up religious pictures and suggest people look at them or recite prayers while working. The only perceptible objects of attention there are the materials, the tools and the movements of work. If these very objects are not transformed into reflections of light, it is impossible for attention during work to be directed towards the source of all light. Nothing is more urgently needed than such a transformation. It is only possible if a reflective property is to be found in the matter that confronts working people. No concoction of arbitrary symbols will do. In truth there is no place for fiction, imagination or dreams. Fortunately for us a reflective property does exist in matter which is like a mirror

misted over by our breath. We have only to wipe the mirror to read in it symbols inscribed in matter through eternity.

Some are contained in the Gospels. Inside a room, if one wishes to think about spiritual death being a prerequisite of true rebirth, one needs words about the seed fertilized by death alone. A sower in the act of sowing, however, may, if he wishes, through his own movements and the sight of the seed entering the earth, direct his attention towards that truth without the help of a single word. If he does not reason around it but simply looks, the undiminished attention he pays to the accomplishment of his task reaches the very highest degree of intensity.

Religious attention is justly called the plenitude of attention. Plenitude of attention is nothing other than prayer. Similarly, the image of the alienation of the soul parched by Christ is like the shrivelling of the branch cut off from the vine. In the great vineyards, pruning takes place over very many days. And likewise, contemplation of the inexhaustible truth it symbolizes can also continue day after day.

It should be easy to find shaped in the nature of things many other symbols which can transfigure not only labour generally but individual tasks themselves. Christ is the bronze serpent which shields from death those who look upon it. Yet our gaze must be uninterrupted and in order for it to be so, the things which our needs and obligations force us to look at must reflect what they prevent us from seeing directly. If a church made by human beings can be full of symbols, how much more full must the universe be. It is infinitely full of them. We must read into them.

The image in the Good Friday hymn of the Cross compared to a scales could be an inexhaustible source of inspiration to those who carry burdens, pull levers and who are by evening exhausted by the weight of things. On the scales a considerable weight placed close to the supporting point may be lifted by a relatively small weight placed at a great distance from it. The body of Christ was a very small weight but with the distance existing between heaven and earth, he counterbalanced the universe. It is often unbearably

heavy, and body and soul are bowed beneath its wearying weight. But the person who is connected to heaven may support that weight, and once he has seen the connection, will not be distracted from it by weariness, tedium or disgust. He will be led back to it constantly.

In the fields, sun and sap are constant reminders of the greatest thing in the world – the fact that we live by solar energy alone. It feeds us, keeps us upright, activates our muscles and operates all our bodily actions. In its different forms it is perhaps the only thing in the universe to act as a countervailing force to gravity. It is through it that trees rise, our arms lift burdens and our motor power is driven. It comes from a source inaccessible to us and towards which we cannot move a single step. It flows down towards us always, and though bathed in it we can never seize it. Only the chlorophyll in plant life can capture it, to make with it our food. Provided that by our efforts the earth is properly prepared, solar energy through chlorophyll becomes solid and enters into us in bread, wine, oil and fruit. All peasant labour consists in the tending of this power in plants, which is a perfect image of Christ.

The laws of mechanics that derive from geometry and govern our machines contain supernatural truths. The oscillation of alternating motion is an image of the earthly condition. Everything belonging to creatures is limited except the desire within us which is the mark of our origin. The yearnings which make us seek the unlimited here on earth are therefore for us the only source of crime and error. The good contained in things is finite and so is the evil. In a general way, a given cause will produce a given effect up to a certain point beyond which, if it continues to act, the effect is reversed. It is God who imposes limit on all things and by whom the sea is bounded. In God, there is but one eternal, unchanging act which, rebounding on itself, has no object outside itself. In creatures there exist only movements directed outside themselves but which, because of their limits, are constrained to oscillate. This oscillation is a pale reflection of exclusively divine self-orientation. In our

machines, the image of this link is that between circular and alternating motion. The circle is also the source of mean proportionals. There is no other perfectly exact way of finding the mean proportional between a unit and a number which is not a square than by drawing a circle. The numbers incommensurable with the unit [*les nombres pour lesquels il n'existe aucune médiation qui les relie naturellement à l'unité*] provide an image of our misery. The circle, which comes from outside in a manner which is transcendental with respect to the domain of numbers and provides the mean, is the image of the sole remedy for that misery. These truths and many others are contained in the simple image of a pulley determining the oscillating motion. Only the most elementary knowledge of geometry is needed to understand these last truths and the very rhythm of work, corresponding as it does to oscillation, helps the body to sense them. A human life-span is a very short time indeed in which to contemplate them.

Many other symbols could be found, some more intimately linked with individual workers' actions. In some cases merely by applying his attitude at work to everything else, a worker could experience the good life. Symbols might also be found for those with routine non-manual jobs. For clerks, these might come from elementary arithmetic, for cashiers, from money and so forth; the stock is inexhaustible. From then on, much could be accomplished. These great images, linked to the ideas of science and general culture, could be passed on to adolescents as part of their studies. They could be used as themes for their celebrations and theatrical ventures. New high days and holidays could be centred around them, such as the eve of that great day when a little fourteen-year-old goes to work alone for the first time. By means of these symbols, men and women could live constantly surrounded by an atmosphere of supernatural poetry, as they did in medieval times, perhaps even better than then, for why limit hope for the good?

In this way workers would be rid of the often painful

feeling of inferiority they experience and also the false confidence which slight contact with intellectualism puts in its place. Intellectuals, for their part, would be rid of their unwarranted snobbery and the equally suspect cult of fashionable ranting that sprang up a few years ago. All those who were able would unite on equal terms at the highest point of full attention, that's to say in the fullness of prayer. Those who were unable would at least know that such a point exists. They would see that the various paths leading up to that point, though separate at lower levels, as by the base of a mountain are all equally viable.

The only serious aim of schoolwork is to train the attention. Attention is the only faculty of the soul which gives access to God. Mental gymnastics rely on an inferior, discursive form of attention, which reasons. Properly directed, however, this attention may give rise in the soul to another, of the highest kind, which is intuitive attention. Pure, intuitive attention is the only source of perfectly beautiful art, truly original and brilliant scientific discovery, of philosophy which really aspires to wisdom and of true, practical love of one's neighbour. This kind of attention when turned to God is true prayer. Just as symbols can enable one to think of God while one is digging or mowing, so only a method of transforming schoolwork into preparation for this superior attention would allow an adolescent solving a problem in geometry or doing a Latin translation to think of God. Without such a transformation, intellectual work for all its apparent independence remains nevertheless servile. In order to attain intuitive attention, those with leisure to do so must exercise to their very utmost the discursive faculties which, while they remain, act as an obstacle. For those whose social function requires them to use those faculties there is probably no other method. For those whose faculties are almost completely paralysed by the fatigue of long daily labour, the possible obstacle is much reduced and the necessary wearing-down minimal. For them, the very work which paralyses, provided it be transformed into poetry, will lead to intuitive attention.

In our society, it is educational rather than economic differences that produce the illusion of social inequality. Marx, who is nearly always very powerful when describing evil, rightly denounced as degrading the separation of manual and intellectual labour. He did not know that in all domains, opposites are unified on a plane transcending both. The meeting point of intellectual and manual work is contemplation, which is no work at all. In no society does the person in charge of a machine exercise the same kind of attention as a person working out a problem. If they wish, however, and if they have a method for doing so, each, in exercising the particular kind of attention required of them by society, can allow another kind to appear and develop. This other kind of attention overrides all social obligations and constitutes a direct link with God.

If students, young peasants and workers could perceive all the various social functions as equal prerequisites to the emergence in the soul of one uniquely valuable faculty, as they perceive cogs in a perfectly straightforward machine, then equality would become a real thing. It would be the principle of both justice and order. It is only through a clear understanding of the supernatural meaning of each social function that the desirability of reform can be judged and injustice defined. Otherwise injustice will be seen inevitably and erroneously as suffering rooted in the nature of things, or undeserved suffering that results from our own crimes will be attributed to the human condition itself. Certain degrees of subordination and monotony are sufferings inherent in the very nature of work and inseparable from a corresponding supernatural meaning. Neither is degrading in itself but anything added to them is both degrading and unjust. Anything which prevents poetry from crystallizing around that suffering is criminal. It is not sufficient to rediscover the lost source of the poetry; working conditions must themselves favour its continued existence. If they are unfavourable, they kill it.

Anything which is inextricably linked with either the desire for or the fear of change should be excluded from

what is essentially a uniform existence and one which should be accepted as such. First, all physical suffering except that which the nature of the work makes unavoidable, for it is impossible to suffer without hoping for relief. Hardships can scarcely be more unendurable than in this social condition. Food, lodging, rest and leisure should be such that a normal working day, taken in itself, should be free of physical suffering. Excess, too, is no less undesirable in this kind of life, for the desire for it is itself unlimited and implies a desire for a change of condition. All advertising and propaganda of all kinds, and anything designed to stimulate the desire for excess in both rural and urban workers should be regarded as criminal. There may be individual flights from the working condition either through unsuitability or the possession of different skills but for those who remain, there should be no improvement in individual well-being that is not at the same time seen as linked to the general. There should be no way for a worker to be afraid of getting too little or hope to get more than he needs. Security should be greater than in any other social condition and unaffected by the fluctuations of supply and demand.

The arbitrary in human life forces the defenceless soul both to hope and to fear. It should therefore be excluded as far as possible from work as should all unnecessary authority. A small peasant holding is thus better than a large one. It follows that big is bad where small is possible and that parts are better manufactured in a small workshop than under the orders of a factory foreman. In the book of Job, death is praised since it prevents the slave from hearing his master's voice. Harm is done each time a commanding voice is raised when a practical arrangement could have been made quietly without it.

The worst outrage, however, is violation of the workers' attention. This is perhaps an example of a sin against the spirit which is unforgivable if committed deliberately. It destroys that faculty of the soul which is the source of all spiritual action. The inferior kind of attention required by

taylorized (conveyor-belt) work is incompatible with any other kind of attention since it drains the soul of all save a preoccupation with speed. This kind of work cannot be transformed and must be stopped. All technological problems should be viewed within the context of what will bring about the best working conditions. This is the most important standard to establish; the whole of society should be first constituted so that work does not demean those who perform it. It is not sufficient that they avoid suffering. Their joy must be desired also, not bought treats but the natural delights that do not cheapen the spirit of poverty. The supernatural poetry which should permeate all their lives could from time to time be concentrated in dazzling celebrations, as necessary in working life as milestones to the walker. Free working holidays like the old *tours de France* would satisfy the youthful appetite for seeing and learning. All should be done so that nothing essential is missing and the best among them may then possess in their daily lives the completeness artists seek to express in their art. If man's vocation is to achieve pure joy through suffering, workers are better placed than all others to accomplish it in the truest way.

From *La Condition Ouvrière*, Gallimard, Paris, 1951, translated by Siân Miles.